

## Chapter 52\_2: Head Pat

Soon dawn arrived, and the villagers woke to find the haze was gone. They immediately rejoiced and celebrated, treating the three as life-saving immortals, kowtowing in gratitude and going to claim the bodies. The originally desolate village finally gained some life.

Ning Fu Yi and Chu Qing Qiu knew that Cui Shu Lan's body had been buried in the pigsty by the fool Er Lang. So they didn't rush to dig up the body, but instead wrote a letter to send to Chuan An City<sup>1</sup>, informing Cui Shu Lan's parents to come claim it. In the letter, they detailed all the wrongs Cui Shu Lan had suffered, but didn't mention the fierce ghost incident.

After completing these tasks, the three of them finally left Axe Head Village. They departed in the early morning, standing on the high mountain and looking down, where rooftops emerged from the misty haze, making the village appear mysterious and peaceful.

It seemed as if it had always been this way—nothing had ever happened, and there had never been a woman named Cui Shu Lan who had spent such dark times here.

When the village could no longer be seen, the depression in Ning Fu Yi's heart eased somewhat. Coincidentally, a fork in the road appeared ahead. Baili Shi Qi needed to take the right path to continue her training elsewhere, so she reluctantly bid them farewell.

"Sister Ning, you are the first fellow daoist I've encountered since beginning my training. It's such a pity that I must continue my chivalrous deeds and cannot accompany you further." Baili Shi Qi's words were full of regret. Her star-like eyes sparkled as she busily fumbled in her spatial pouch<sup>2</sup> at her waist.

"I must give Sister a meeting gift so that Sister Ning won't forget me!"

What she pulled out were all treasures difficult to find across the four seas and eight wastelands—either deep-sea agates or Tianshan spirit jade<sup>3</sup>, and even several priceless divine weapons. She stuffed them all into Ning Fu Yi's hands, smiling obediently: "Which one does Sister Ning like? Just take it!"

She was indeed the young lady of Penglai<sup>4</sup>. Just one divine weapon thrown into a group of disciples would cause a mad scramble, yet she pulled out so many at once.

While marveling at the differences between people, Ning Fu Yi was also amazed that there could be such pure people in the world—their thoughts so pure, untainted by any impurities.

She no longer had the heart to laugh at her, and instead pushed all those treasures back, her voice much gentler: "No need to give me anything. I won't forget you."

Hearing this, Baili Shi Qi became anxious: "That won't do..."

"How about this?" Seeing she was difficult to persuade, Ning Fu Yi suddenly remembered the yingluo<sup>5</sup> she had picked up that day. So she took it out from her prayer bead<sup>6</sup>, took one of the scattered gemstones from it, and returned the rest to her.

Hearing this, Baili Shi Qi's smile bloomed again. She nodded repeatedly and carefully put away the yingluo.

"Sister Ning, may we meet again by fate!" she said to Ning Fu Yi. "Please also bid farewell to Auntie for me."

After saying this, she looked at Ning Fu Yi with reluctance once more, then turned around and disappeared bouncing among the tree shadows.

Ning Fu Yi played with the spirit stone for a moment, and when she turned back, she found Chu Qing Qiu had long disappeared. Looking up, she could see Bai Lin's<sup>7</sup> rear end had already become a light dot.

"Divine Venerable!" she exclaimed in surprise.

Ning Fu Yi flew on her sword for quite a while before catching up to Chu Qing Qiu. She put away her sword and jumped onto Bai Lin's back, breathless, only to see Chu Qing Qiu sitting sideways on Bai Lin's tail, her feet dangling, staring into the horizon in a daze.

White clouds rolled by, and her profile was more beautiful than every cloud.

Ning Fu Yi exhaled and slowly walked over, carefully sitting down beside her.

"What is Divine Venerable thinking about?"

"Nothing."

"Are you feeling sorry for Cui Shu Lan?" Ning Fu Yi asked.

"No."

Ning Fu Yi bit her lip and looked toward the horizon together with Chu Qing Qiu: "I originally thought Divine Venerable was the type with a cold heart and clear mind, with your own set of rules, unable to generate even half a bit of sympathy for all living beings."

In her previous life, she had indeed thought this way.

But when facing Cui Shu Lan, she clearly saw her moved by mortal feelings, deliberately awakening that woman who had done many evil deeds.

Actually, even if the woman hadn't been scared to death, when the prefect learned of his daughter's fate, she certainly wouldn't have survived. But Cui Shu Lan wouldn't have seen such an ending.

"I lost my composure. I will accept punishment when I return to the sect," Chu Qing Qiu said indifferently.

"Am I also always that cold person in everyone's heart?" Chu Qing Qiu suddenly asked. This question didn't seem like something she would care about, so Ning Fu Yi was momentarily dazed.

"Not really," she swung her legs. "Only in my heart."

"Then what would not be considered cold?"

This question stumped Ning Fu Yi. She scratched her hair and answered half-jokingly: "If Divine Venerable treated me with half the warmth you show Qiu Yi<sup>8</sup>, that wouldn't be considered cold."

As she was speaking, she suddenly felt a comfortable sensation on the top of her head. Someone was stroking her hair, a delicate and warm palm lingering among her strands. Her smile immediately froze on her face.

"Like this?" Chu Qing Qiu asked.

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### Footnotes:

1. **Chuan An City (川安城)**: The city where Cui Shu Lan originally lived with her family
2. **Spatial pouch (海纳百川的荷包)**: A magical storage item that can hold many objects despite its small size; literally means "pouch that contains all rivers and seas"
3. **Tianshan spirit jade (天山灵玉)**: Precious jade from the Heavenly Mountains, imbued with spiritual energy
4. **Penglai (蓬莱)**: One of the immortal realms, known for its wealth and noble cultivator families
5. **Yingluo (璎珞)**: Traditional Chinese beaded jewelry or ornamental chains
6. **Prayer bead (一念珠)**: Ning Fu Yi's magical storage item
7. **Bai Lin (白麟)**: Chu Qing Qiu's white qilin (mythical creature) mount
8. **Qiu Yi (秋亦)**: Chu Qing Qiu's disciple, whom she treats with evident care and warmth